Presents

NIT Raipur's E-SUMMIT 26

HOLD THE VISION

22–24 MARCH

THE ENTREPRENEURSHIP CELL NIT RAIPUR

ANANTYA

The Entrepreneurship Cell

BUSINESS CASE STUDY

ZEPTO'S RACE AGAINST TIME: REDEFINING QUICKCOMMERCE SUSTAINABILITY

2026

Problem Statement

Background

Zepto emerged as a disruptor in India's quick-commerce landscape, promising 10-minute grocery deliveries and redefining convenience for urban consumers. Backed by young founders and strong investor confidence, it quickly became one of India's fastest-growing startups.

However, by 2026, the quick-commerce industry faces a profitability crisis. Rising delivery costs, thin margins, and saturation in metro markets have begun to slow Zepto's growth. The company's dependency on heavy discounts and high operational expenses has further strained its financial sustainability.

At the same time, Blinkit, owned by Zomato, has expanded its ecosystem by offering services such as ambulance-on-call, medicine delivery, and premium speed logistics, giving it a major competitive advantage. Rivals such as Swiggy Instamart and BigBasket are also leveraging scale and diversification to capture market share.

In this high-pressure environment, Zepto must reinvent its business model—moving from a "speedobsessed" brand to a sustainability-driven platform that balances growth with long-term profitability

Problem Statement

Task

As members of Zepto's strategic leadership team, participants are required to develop a comprehensive roadmap focused on profitability and long-term sustainability to secure the company's competitive position in India's rapidly evolving quick-commerce ecosystem.

Teams are encouraged to approach the challenge from a specific leadership perspective, such as:

CEO Perspective – Driving overall business transformation, long-term growth strategy, and market expansion.

CFO Perspective – Strengthening unit economics, optimizing cost structures, and designing a clear profitability pathway.

COO Perspective – Enhancing operational efficiency, logistics optimization, and supply-chain effectiveness.

CMO Perspective – Repositioning the brand, improving customer engagement, and strengthening market differentiation.

Participants may develop solutions from a single leadership role or integrate multiple leadership perspectives to create a well-rounded strategic framework.

Proposed solutions should be clear, actionable, and concise. Well-defined strategic recommendations— including direct, single-line insights where appropriate—are acceptable if they effectively address the core challenges.

Problem Statement

Key Focus Areas

- **Unit Economics Optimization**
  - Identify cost-reduction levers (last-mile efficiency, dark-store utilization, delivery-partner model).
  - Redesign incentives and logistics systems to achieve break-even per order.
- **Product Mix & Revenue Diversification**
  - Prioritize margin-rich categories such as FMCG, fresh produce, and ready-to-cook products. –
  - Explore allied verticals like micro-pharmacy, essentials delivery, or subscription-based "Zepto Care."
- **Operational Innovation**
  - Implement data-driven inventory management and predictive demand analytics.
  - Use AI-based routing systems to reduce fuel consumption and delivery time.
- **Brand Strategy & Positioning**
  - Reposition Zepto as reliable and responsible, not just fast.
  - Build brand trust through eco-friendly packaging, transparent pricing, and community engagement.
- **Competitive Strategy Against Blinkit & Others**
  - Counter Blinkit's diversification with differentiated services such as health-focused quick-delivery partnerships or hyperlocal collaborations.
  - Explore partnerships with healthcare startups to strategically enter adjacent verticals.
- **Sustainability & ESG Initiatives**
  - Implement green delivery fleets and reusable packaging solutions.
  - Set measurable carbon-reduction goals to attract environmentally conscious consumers and investors.

Problem Statement

Reference Articles / Sources

- https://www.business-standard.com/industry/news/zepto-closes-gap-with-blinkit-in-quick commerce-app-installation-reach-126012201200_1.html

(Competition between Zepto and Blinkit in quick commerce) Business Standard

- https://voice.lapaas.com/zepto-third-qcommerce-india/

(Market share shifts and Zepto's position in quick commerce) Lapaas Voice

- https://www.moneycontrol.com/news/business/startup/blinkit-zepto-ahead-of-swiggy instamart-in-quick-commerce-says-citi-12939208.html

(Market share analysis of Blinkit, Zepto, and Instamart) Moneycontrol

- https://news.abplive.com/business/zepto-raises-one-billion-quick-commerce-blinkit-swiggy eternal-big-basket-1803778

(Zepto's profitability strategy through ads and private labels) ABP Live

- https://www.business-standard.com/companies/news/flipkart-s-tryst-with-quick-commerce will-zepto-blinkit-feel-the-pinch-124031801070_1.html

(Industry analysis of quick-commerce competition and economics) Business Standard

- https://arxiv.org/abs/2510.11360

(Research paper on pricing and profitability in quick-commerce models)

Problem Statement

Judging Criteria

Submissions will be evaluated based on:

- **Creativity & Innovation** – Unique, data-driven, and sustainable ideas that redefine Zepto's quick commerce model.
- **Market Understanding** – Clear insights into consumer behavior, competitive positioning (especially Blinkit's diversification), and evolving quick-commerce trends.
- **Strategic Execution** – Well structured, actionable steps that demonstrate how Zepto can move toward profitability while maintaining brand reliability.
- **Financial Viability & Scalability** – Realistic cost-saving measures, profitability roadmap, and potential for expansion across major Indian metros.
- **Sustainability & Impact** – Environmentally conscious, long term strategies that emphasize eco friendly logistics and packaging.
- **Presentation & Persuasion** – Clarity, logical flow, and the ability to effectively communicate why the proposed strategy will help Zepto thrive against Blinkit and Swiggy Instamart.